

fair amount of initial investment and hence, the start-up operation will be more expensive than the conventional non-tech office. But, a well-designed and well-linked office will be able to pay for its investment within a short period," he says.

The Conference Room

What can easily be called the great coliseum in an organisation, the conference room is one of the most important areas. Given today's pressures and tech-readiness most employees have, the room should not need to be "prepared" before each meeting.

Some of the most important aspects of a conference room are the projector, projector screen, a computer for playing presentations, a phone with conferencing facility and a video-conferencing facility.

The layout of the conference room must be conference-friendly and the computer should ideally possess the following: a DVD combo drive, USB ports, memory card slots and a lot of RAM so that the presentations don't drag around. Remember, this is also the room where you would possibly be making an impression on the client. So let 'er rip!

A good projector is a long-term investment. But having the right one to suit your needs and your conference room is a major task. While the range of projectors available is vast, you need to make sure you get just the right one for your office. (Refer the January 2005 issue of *Digit* for more on projectors)

Videoconferencing is gaining in popularity, and if you could "meet" with the client without having to leave your office, what a way to save time and money!

Says Yugal Sharma, country manager, Polycom India, a video conferencing major: "Video conferencing boosts productivity—there are no two ways about it. Executives globally, and even in India, have reported benefits thanks to faster decision-making, improved employee morale, improved access to the best talent, reduced time to market, better customer responsiveness, more efficient work practices, fewer concerns about travel problems, and a greater focus on results overall. And, of course, measurable costs like travel and accommodation are reduced."

The Boss' Room

Contrary to what you might think, bosses do have a lot of work, and therefore, require all the space and gadgets they normally have in their rooms! An ideal room for a boss would be a hi-tech, efficient place where things happen at the touch of a button.

As boss, you probably carry a range of gadgets, and with good reason. Your laptop, cell phone, PDA, pen drive, and a whole lot of data spread across these devices is your lifeline.

You also need to attend a lot of meetings and keep track of a variety of other intra-office activities and events including birthdays, anniversaries, appraisals and more. How does one person accomplish all this on time? Synchronising data on various devices is one way



A tech intensive office will definitely involve a fair amount of initial investment... But a well-linked and well-designed office will pay back the investment in a short span of time

V Krishnan

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of ensuring you never forget. At any given point, at least one of the devices would be with you. So even if your PDA is in your bag, the cell phone would remind you of a meeting or a birthday. This job could also be carried out by the secretary and you need not worry about missing another appointment.

In fact, if your PDA is e-mail compliant and can support MS Word, Excel and PowerPoint files, you need not worry about not having a file during a meeting.

You could ask your secretary to e-mail it to you. You could then download it using either Bluetooth or Infrared, and you're good to go!

Tomorrow's Office

While these setups are possibly enough in today's scenario, imagine having an office where anyone could sit in any cubicle without having to worry about any kind of setup.

Given that all cubicles are identical in size and have the same hardware, employees could simply choose the cubicle closest to their team with every change and their data, e-mail and extension would follow automatically. How?

Your identity card would be the most important tool at work. With every cubicle being identical, there would be a swipe facility outside the cubicle. Simply swiping your ID card would mean that the computer in that cubicle would open your e-mail account and personal settings and the Internet phone in the cubicle would simply assume your extension.

This process repeats every time you change your cubicle. With all your data on the network and safely encrypted, the only thing you need to carry around is your coffee mug!

All this sounds good but isn't it a little fancy? "A number of functions in today's situations can only be performed using intelligent devices and hence, technology and gadgets can only help augment the mental capability of an individual and help perform his/her tasks far more efficiently," says Krishnan. ☐

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